# Project 3: the letters (the Sumerian letters of private life; ETCSL 5.5.1 and 3.3.x)

▼ Contents


**Scope** 1

**Base text** 1

**Line numbering** 2

**Formulas (renderings §3.3)** 2

**Open decisions** 2

**Progress** 2

Review passes (2026-10-21) 3

**Key findings (project 3)** 3


## Scope

The Message of Lu-diĝira to his mother (ETCSL 5.5.1, 57 lines with 44A, 52A, 52B) and eight letters of the OB Sumerian epistolary curriculum that concern private life: 3.3.07 (Ugubi to his mother, 11), 3.3.06 (Aba-taḫ-lugalĝa to his brothers, 13), 3.3.01 (Ur-saga to a king, 14), 3.3.10 (Inanaka to Nintinuga, 26), 3.3.20 (Gudea to his personal god, 10), 3.3.08 (Šamaš-ṭāb to Ilak-niʾid, 19), 3.3.11 and 3.3.12 (Inim-Inana to Enlil-massu and Lugal-ibila, 15 + 13) – 178 lines. Not included: the royal correspondence of Ur (3.1.x) and the royal letter-prayers (3.2.x), which are political.

**The Old Babylonian Akkadian private letters (AbB) were planned but not obtained:** CDLI (`cdli.earth`) answered HTTP 503 all day (2026-10-21); Archibab is not on the allowlist; eBL's fragmentarium has OB letters but no searchable edition. A later run should take them (e.g. the letters of sons to mothers – Iddin-Sîn to Zinû, TCL 18 111 –, the Mari women, the Old Assyrian wives) from CDLI.

## Base text

ETCSL (`../../sources/ETCSL/5.5.1--...`, `3.3.0N--...`, CC BY-NC-SA) with ORACC epsd2/literary Q000775, Q000573, Q000578, Q000579, Q000580, Q000582, Q000583, Q000584, Q000592 (lemma + morph). ETCSL's English is rank 3. Some letters carry Akkadian glosses in the manuscripts (`(gloss: ...)` in the transliteration): they are evidence for the ancient understanding and are translated in the apparatus.

## Line numbering

ETCSL composite numbers (44A, 52A, 52B in 5.5.1 are pluses of single manuscripts). Files: `annotated-ludigira.rtl.md` (LUD), `annotated-letters.rtl.md` (the eight letters, units marked `<!-- unit: KEY -->`).

## Formulas (renderings §3.3)

Opening *X-ra $u_3$-na-dug$_4$* / *Y na-ab-be$_2$-a* = אֶל X זֶה אֲשֶׁר / אֱמֹר: אוֹמֵר Y:; closing *a-ma-ru-kam* = מַבּוּל הוּא!.

## Open decisions

1. *gi$_4$* "send (back)" = שָׁלַח where it means sending a person (5.5.1 2; 3.3.12 4, 10), הֵשִׁיב / שׁוּב where it means return (5.5.1 45; 3.3.01 7; 3.3.08 14; 3.3.11 11; 3.3.20 10): one Sumerian verb, two Hebrew verbs by sense; the gate שוב is licensed in both.
2. *ḫi-li* = חֵן in the letters and the proverbs (5.5.1 25, 31, 38; 1.197), against Akk. *kuzbu* = עֶגְבִים (project 1): the Sumerian word is wider (the mother's charm).
3. *lu-lim* = יַחְמוּר (22 5.5.1; Gilgameš *lulīmu*), though ETCSL reads "doe"; *mar-šum* = כְּסֵא־נְשִׂיאָה, not אַפִּרְיוֹן (which would import Song 3:9).
4. *tukum-bi X an-na-kam* "if it is X's approval" = אם רצון X (19 3.3.10 ,11 3.3.01) הוא, keeping טוֹב for the one manuscript with *$u_3$-na-an-dug$_3$* (noted).
5. *ušbar* = חָם from the wife's side (5.5.1 14), חוֹתֵן from the husband's side (proverb 1.169).
6. *lul-aš* "falsely, in vain" = בלי שקר ,(7 3.3.06) לשווא (3 3.3.11, "beyond lying"); *lul* elsewhere שָׁקָר.
7. *a-zu* = רוֹפֵא; *tu$_6$* (= *šiptu*) = קָסָם (the open cross-corpus choice); *mu$_7$-mu$_7$* = לַחַשׁ. **Settled 2026-10-21 (the lead's harmonization): *tu$_6$* = קָסָם kept.**
8. **Settled 2026-10-21 (the lead's cross-corpus harmonization, `../renderings.md` §9):** *za-gin$_3$* = סַפִּיר [equivalent] (was 30 5.5.1 ,1 3.3.01 ;לָזוּרִית, each with the note on Exod 24:10, Ezek 1:26, Job 28:6); *a-ra-zu* = תַּחֲנוּן (was 6 3.3.10 ;תפילה); *šudu$_3$* = בְּרָכָה, *sizkur$_2$* = תְּפִלָּה as before. Open: *šag$_4$-ne-ša$_4$* (= *unnīnu*) (5 3.3.10) תחנונים shares its root with *a-ra-zu* תַּחֲנוּן in the next line.

## Progress

Drafted by the run-7 coordinator acting as the translator (see `../handoff--round2-run7.md` §6):

- 2026-10-21: the Message of Lu-diĝira (57 lines, `annotated-ludigira.rtl.md`); the eight letters (121 lines, `annotated-letters.rtl.md`). All 178 lines; `translation.rtl.md` built.

## Review passes (2026-10-21)

1. **Fidelity and Hebrew**: a read-through of all `>` lines; fixed `ברוך` "gently" (caught by the blessing gate: `בעדינות`), `הגן` for *mu₂-sar* "vegetable plot" (`ערוגות הירק`: no *kiri₆*), `שמן העונג` (a misreading of `שמן` "from": rephrased), `לשאול` (contains the never-string `נשאל`: `שאול`), an `(אהוב)` addition without *ki aĝ₂* (removed).
2. **Consistency** (by script): the key-lemma check (misses: the *gi₄* sense split, decision 1; `שׂוּמִים` plene); `verify LET` with the four letter formulas (opening *u₃-na-dug₄* in its three line-shapes, *na-ab-be₂-a* `אומרת/אומר ... אשר זה:`, *u₃-na-de₃-taḫ* `הוסף:`, *a-ma-ru-kam* `מַבּוּל הוּא!`) and the five "signs" of 5.5.1 (`אוֹת ... אתן לך:`).
3. **Echo control and quotations**: every quotation printed before use and `check_bible_quotes.py` clean; four notes first written with "not a quotation" memory quotes were replaced by printed verses (one of them, Gen 37:14, had been misremembered: `לְכָה נָּא` for `לֶךְ נָא`).

# Key findings (project 3)

- **A wasf of a mother**: 5.5.1's five "signs" describe the mother with the images of the Song of Songs' wasfs and of the "woman of valour": the house kept straight and the possessions multiplied (14–18 ↔ משלי לא:טז, כז), "more precious than carnelian" (24 ↔ משלי לא:י), the morning star (23 ↔ שיר השירים ו:י), the garden, the palm and the clusters (35, 48, 51 ↔ שיר השירים ד:יג; ז:ח), the sedan chair of precious wood (49 ↔ ג:ט), ivory (31 ↔ ה:יד; ז:ה), "good oil" (20 ↔ קהלת ז:א), and charm (*ḫi-li*) praised where Proverbs calls it "a lie" (25 ↔ משלי לא:ל).
- **"Your son is well"**: the end of 5.5.1 (54 `שלום – בנך האהוב, לוּ־דִינְגִּירָה!`) ↔ `כֹּה אָמַר בִּנְךָ יוֹסֵף` (בראשית מה:ט) and `עוֹד יוֹסֵף חַי` (בראשית מה:כו); the mother who cannot sleep (4) and the captive returning to his mother (46 ↔ ירמיהו לא:טז, `וְשָׁבוּ בָנִים לִגְבוּלָם`).
- **The father's house**: Ur-saga asks the king that no one take his father's house (3.3.01 12–13 ↔ Naboth, מלכים א כא:ג); the daughters of Zelophehad, במדבר כז:ד); the king's word that cannot be turned back (7 ↔ אסתר ח:ח, `אֵין לְהָשִׁיב`).
- **The sick woman's letter-prayer** (3.3.10): the friends who stand far off (15 ↔ תהלים לח:יב; פח:יט), the vow to serve in the temple court (23 ↔ תהלים פד:יא), "on the ground of life I will set my feet" and "I will call your name" (21, 25 ↔ תהלים קטז:ט, יג), "your maidservant" (11 ↔ שמואל א א:יא).
- **"Like sheep without a shepherd"**: Gudea's letter to his god (3.3.20 3 ↔ במדבר כז:יז), and "may your heart return to its place" (10 ↔ תהלים ו:ה, `שׁוּבָה יְהוָה`).
- **Everyday life**: a homesick boy complaining that the bread and beer are stale (3.3.07); a brother leaving his mother in his brothers' care (3.3.06); a merchant's expense account in shekels, minas and talents, paid in tin (3.3.08 ↔ בראשית כג:טז, `שָׁקָל כֶּסֶף עֹבֵר לַסּוֹחֵר`); a teacher sending silver and clothes to a pupil, and warning a colleague not to neglect Sumerian or let the children leave school without an agreed sign (3.3.11–12). The letter formula ends with "it is a flood!" – `מַבּוּל הוּא!`, "urgent".